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SECURITY



**Sex toy maker Lovense
threatens legal action
after fixing security flaws
that exposed users' data**

Lovense, a maker of internet-connected sex toys, has confirmed it has [fixed a pair of security vulnerabilities](#) that exposed users' private email addresses and allowed attackers to remotely take over any user's account.

While the company said the bugs were “fully resolved,” its chief executive is now considering taking legal action following the disclosure.

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In [a statement](#) shared with TechCrunch, Lovense CEO Dan Liu said the sex toy maker was “investigating the possibility of legal action” in response to allegedly erroneous reports about the bug. When asked by TechCrunch, the company did not respond to clarify whether it was referring to media reports or to a security researcher's disclosure.

IMAGE CREDITS: EVGENIA SHULIM / GETTY IMAGES

Details of the bug emerged this week after a security researcher, who goes by the handle BobDaHacker, disclosed that they [reported the two security bugs](#) to the sex toy maker earlier this year. The researcher published their findings after Lovense claimed it would take 14 months to fully address the vulnerabilities rather than applying a “faster, one-month fix” that would have required alerting users to update their apps.

Lovense said in its statement, attributed to Liu, that the fixes put in place will require users to update their apps before they can resume using all of the app's features.

In the statement, Liu claimed that there is “no evidence suggesting that any user data, including email addresses or account information, has been compromised or misused.” It's not clear how Lovense came to this conclusion, given TechCrunch ([and other outlets](#)) verified

the email disclosure bug by setting up a new account and asking the researcher to identify the associated email address.

TechCrunch asked Lovense what technical means, such as logs, the company has to determine if there was any compromise of users’ data, but a spokesperson did not respond.

It’s not unheard of for organizations to resort to legal demands and threats to try to block the disclosure of embarrassing security incidents, despite few rules or restrictions in the U.S. prohibiting such reporting.

Earlier this year, a U.S. independent journalist [rebuffed a legal threat](#) from a U.K. court injunction for accurately reporting a ransomware attack on U.K. private healthcare giant HCRG. In 2023, a county official in Hillsborough County, Florida, [threatened criminal charges against a security researcher](#) under the state’s computer hacking laws for identifying and privately disclosing a security flaw in the county’s court records system that exposed access to sensitive filings.

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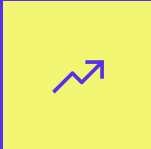
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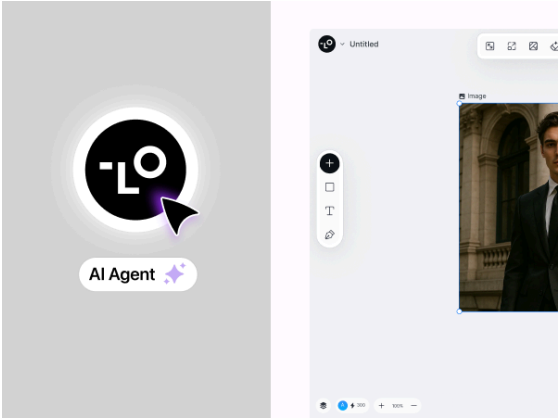
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SonicWall urges customers to disable SSLVPN amid reports of ransomware attacks

Zack Whittaker — 6:48 AM PDT · August 5, 2025

Enterprise security company SonicWall is urging its customers to disable a core feature of its most recent line-up of firewall devices after security researchers reported an uptick in ransomware incidents targeting SonicWall customers.

In [a statement this week](#), SonicWall said it had observed a “notable increase” of security incidents targeting its Generation 7 firewalls where customers have its VPN enabled. The company said it is “actively investigating these incidents to determine whether they are connected to a previously disclosed vulnerability or if a new vulnerability may be responsible.”

The company’s alert comes as security researchers say they have identified hackers targeting SonicWall devices to gain initial access to a victim’s network.

Hackers are [increasingly targeting enterprise products](#), like firewalls and VPNs, which work as digital gatekeepers, allowing legitimate employees access to the company’s network. But security flaws in these products can allow malicious hackers in, enabling attackers to launch data-stealing or destructive attacks.

Security firm Arctic Wolf [said it has seen intrusions](#) targeting SonicWall customers as far back as mid-July. The company said “available evidence points to the existence of a zero-day vulnerability,” referring to a security bug that was discovered and exploited before the vendor could patch the issue.

The researchers said they witnessed a short gap between the exploitation of the SonicWall firewall and the subsequent deployment of file-encrypting malware, or ransomware.

Huntress Labs, another cybersecurity firm, said it [is “likely” that a zero-day bug in SonicWall firewalls is to blame](#) for the attacks, and warned that the hackers exploiting the bug have been seen gaining access to a company’s domain controllers, which manages the devices and users on that network.

In its blog, Huntress said it believes the Akira ransomware gang is behind some of the attacks targeting SonicWall

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customers. Akira has been known to target enterprise products, [like Fortinet firewalls](#), to break into large networks.

“This is a critical, ongoing threat,” wrote Huntress.

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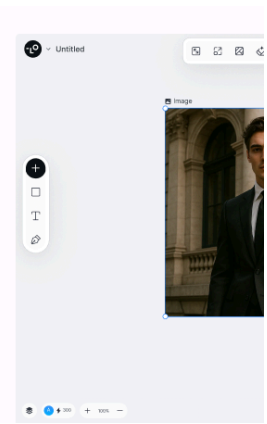
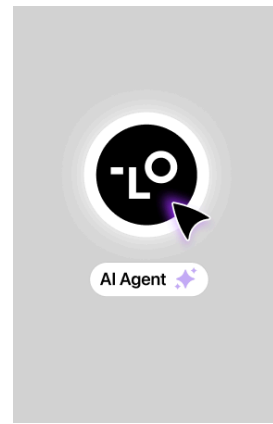
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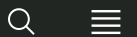
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Sex toy maker Lovense caught leaking users' email addresses and exposing accounts to takeovers



A security researcher says sex toy maker Lovense has

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sex toys and is said to have [more than 20 million users](#). The company made headlines in 2023 for becoming one of the first sex toy makers [to integrate ChatGPT into its products](#).

But the inherent security risks in connecting sex toys to the internet can put users at risk of real-world harm if something goes wrong, including [device lock-ins](#) and [data privacy leaks](#).

BobDaHacker said they discovered that Lovense was leaking people's email addresses while using the app. Although other users' email addresses were not visible to users in the app, anyone using a network analysis tool to inspect the data flowing in and out of the app would see the other user's email address when interacting with them, such as muting them.

By modifying the network request from a logged-in account, BobDaHacker said they could associate any Lovense username with their registered email address, potentially exposing any customer who has signed up to Lovense with an identifiable email address.

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai
- 16 hours ago

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“This was especially bad for cam models who share their usernames publicly but obviously don’t want their personal emails exposed,” BobDaHacker wrote in their blog post.

TechCrunch verified this bug by creating a new account on Lovense and asking BobDaHacker to reveal our registered email address, which they did in about a minute. By automating the process with a computer script, the researcher said they could obtain a user’s email address in less than a second.

BobDaHacker said a second vulnerability allowed them to take over any Lovense user’s account using just their email address, which could be derived from the earlier bug. This bug lets anyone create authentication tokens for accessing a Lovense account without needing a password, allowing an attacker to remotely control the account as if they were the real user.

“Cam models use these tools for work, so this was a huge deal. Literally anyone could take over any account just by knowing the email address,” said BobDaHacker.

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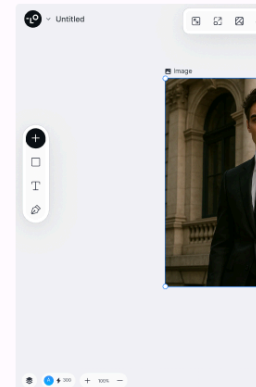
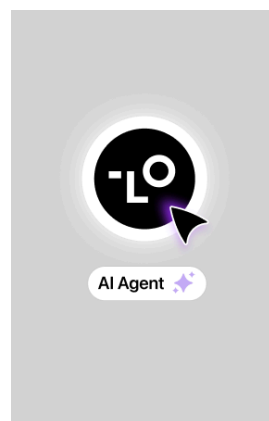
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The bugs affect anyone with a Lovense account or device.

BobDaHacker disclosed the bugs to Lovense on March 26 via the [Internet of Dongs](#), a project that aims to improve the security and privacy of sex toys and helps [report and disclose flaws to device makers](#).

According to BobDaHacker, they were awarded a total of \$3,000 via bug bounty site HackerOne. But after several weeks of back-and-forth disputing whether the bugs were actually fixed, the researcher went public this week after Lovense requested 14 months to fix the flaws. (Security researchers typically grant vendors three months or less to fix a security bug before going public with their findings.) The company told BobDaHacker in the same email that it decided against a “faster, one-month fix,” which would

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have required forcing customers using older products to upgrade their apps immediately.

The researcher notified the company ahead of disclosure, per an email seen by TechCrunch. BobDaHacker said in a blog post update on Tuesday that the bug may have been identified by another researcher as far back as September 2023, but the bug was allegedly closed without a fix.

Lovense did not respond to an email from TechCrunch sent prior to publication. After we published, a Lovense representative said the account takeover bug “has now been fully addressed” and that the email disclosure bug will be patched in an update expected to be “pushed to all users within the next week.” The representative would not commit to publicly notifying its customers about the bugs.

Updated with comment from Lovense.

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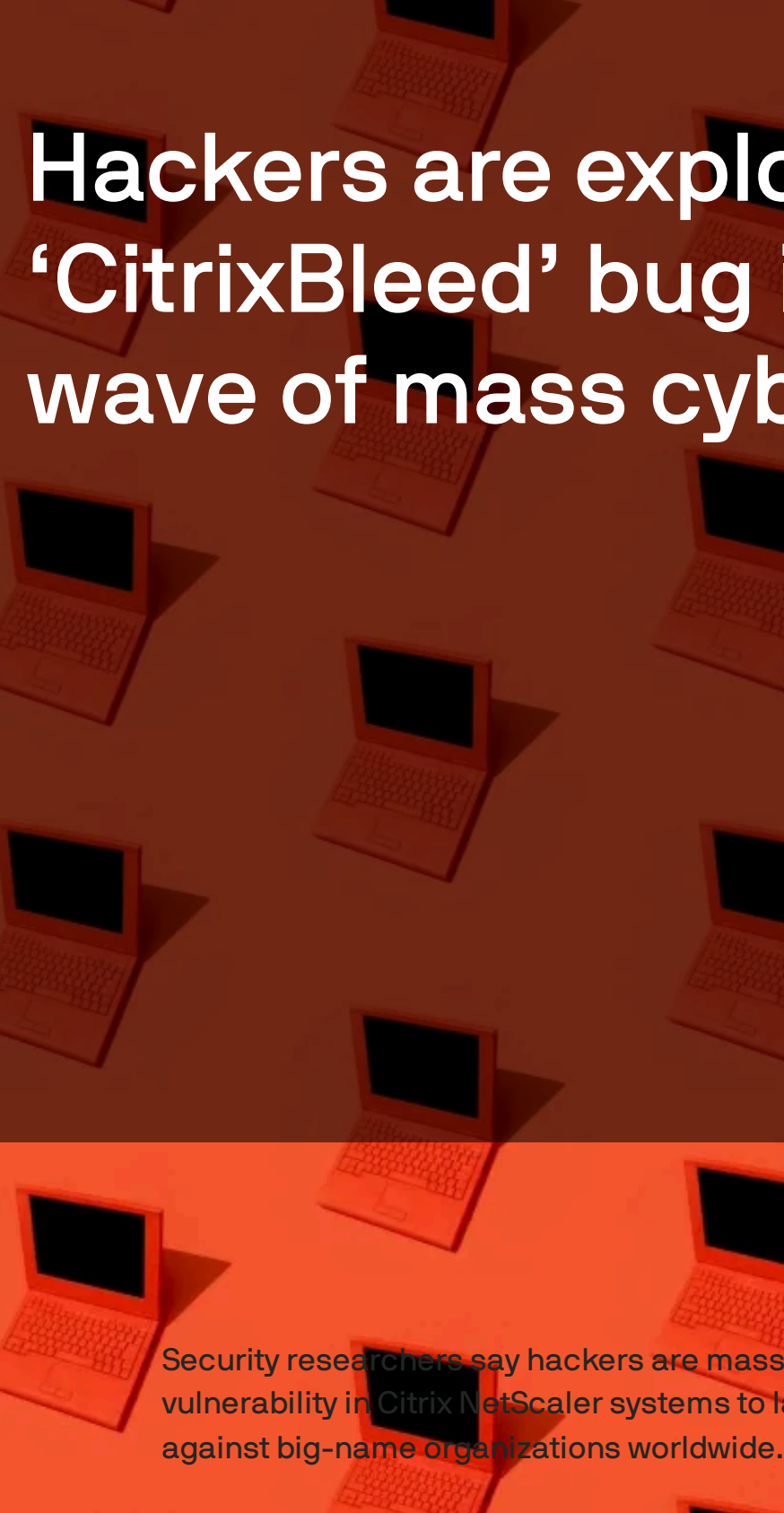
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Hackers are exploiting 'CitrixBleed' bug in the latest wave of mass cyberattacks

Citrix customers urged to patch as
ransomware gang takes credit for
hacking big-name firms

Carly Page

12:00 PM PST · November 14, 2023

Security researchers say hackers are mass-exploiting a critical-rated vulnerability in Citrix NetScaler systems to launch crippling cyberattacks against big-name organizations worldwide.

These cyberattacks [have so far included aerospace giant Boeing](#); the world's biggest bank, ICBC; one of the world's largest port operators, DP World; and international law firm Allen & Overy, according to reports.

Thousands of other organizations remain unpatched against the vulnerability, tracked officially as [CVE-2023-4966](#) and dubbed "CitrixBleed." The majority of affected systems are located in North America, according to [nonprofit threat tracker Shadowserver Foundation](#). The U.S. government's cybersecurity agency CISA has also sounded the alarm [in an advisory urging federal agencies to patch](#) against the actively exploited flaw.

Here's what we know so far.

What is CitrixBleed?

On October 10, network equipment maker Citrix disclosed the vulnerability affecting on-premise versions of its NetScaler ADC and NetScaler Gateway platforms, which large enterprises and governments use for application delivery and VPN connectivity.

The flaw is described as a sensitive information disclosure vulnerability that allows remote unauthenticated attackers to extract large amounts of data from a vulnerable Citrix device's memory, including sensitive session tokens (hence the name "CitrixBleed"). The bug requires little effort or complexity to exploit, allowing hackers to hijack and use legitimate session tokens to compromise a victim's network without needing a password or using two-factor.

Citrix released patches, but a week later on October 17 updated its advisory to advise that it had observed exploitation in the wild.

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Early victims included professional services, technology and government organizations, [according to incident response giant Mandiant](#), which said it began investigating after discovering “multiple instances of successful exploitation” as early as late-August before Citrix made patches available.

Robert Knapp, head of incident response at cybersecurity firm Rapid7 — which also [began investigating the bug](#) after detecting potential exploitation of the bug in a customer’s network — said the company has also observed attackers targeting organizations across healthcare, manufacturing and retail.

“Rapid7 incident responders have observed both lateral movement and data access in the course of our investigations,” said Knapp, suggesting hackers are able to gain broader access to victims’ network and data after initial compromise.

Big-name victims

Cybersecurity company ReliaQuest said [last week](#) it has evidence that at least four threat groups — which it did not name — are leveraging CitrixBleed, with at least one group automating the attack process.

One of the threat actors is believed to be the [Russia-linked LockBit ransomware gang](#), which has already claimed responsibility for several large-scale breaches believed to be associated with CitrixBleed.

Security researcher [Kevin Beaumont wrote in a blog post](#) Tuesday that the LockBit gang last week hacked into the U.S. branch of Industrial and Commercial Bank of China (ICBC) — said to be the world’s largest lender by assets — by compromising an unpatched Citrix Netscaler box. The outage disrupted the banking giant’s ability to clear trades. [According to Bloomberg on Tuesday](#), the firm has yet to restore normal operations.

ICBC, which reportedly paid LockBit’s ransom demand, declined to answer TechCrunch’s questions but said in a statement on its website that it “experienced a ransomware attack” that “resulted in disruption to certain systems.”

A LockBit representative [told Reuters on Monday](#) that ICBC “paid a ransom — deal closed,” but did not provide evidence of their claim. LockBit also [told malware research group vx-underground](#) that ICBC paid a ransom, but declined to say how much.

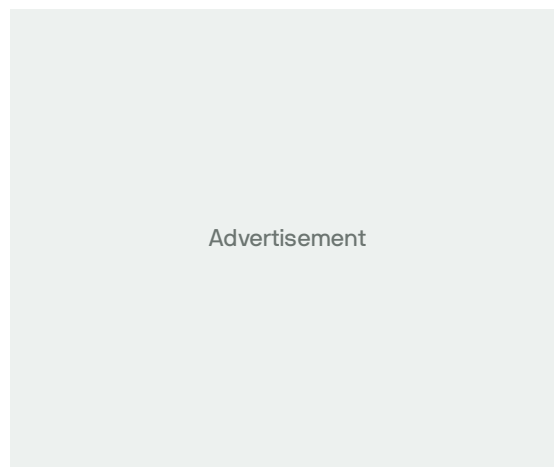
Lockbit ransomware group administrative staff claim ICBC has already paid the ransom demand. pic.twitter.com/5gXDlebLuX

— vx-underground (@vxunderground) [November 14, 2023](#)

Beaumont [said in a post on Mastodon](#) that Boeing also had an unpatched Citrix Netscaler system at the time of its LockBit breach, citing data from Shodan, a search engine for exposed databases and devices.

Boeing spokesperson Jim Proulx previously told TechCrunch that the company is “aware of a cyber incident impacting elements of our parts and distribution business” but would not comment on LockBit’s alleged publication of stolen data.

Allen & Overy, one of the world’s largest law firms, was also running an affected Citrix system at the time of its compromise, Beaumont noted. LockBit added both Boeing and Allen & Overy to its dark web leak site, which ransomware gangs typically use to extort victims by publishing files unless [the victims pay a ransom demand](#).



Allen & Overy spokesperson Debbie Spitz confirmed the law firm experienced a “data incident” and said it was “assessing exactly what data has been impacted, and we are informing affected clients.”

The Medusa ransomware gang is also exploiting CitrixBleed to compromise targeted organizations, [said Beaumont](#).

“We would expect CVE-2023-4966 to be one of the top routinely exploited vulnerabilities from 2023,” Rapid7’s head of vulnerability research Caitlin Condon told TechCrunch.

[Hackers exploit Citrix zero-day to target US critical infrastructure](#)

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Carly Page was a Senior Reporter at TechCrunch, where she covered the cybersecurity beat. Prior to that, she had spent more than a decade in the technology industry, writing for titles including Forbes, TechRadar and WIRED....

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